

paralleled experience for travellers.

Sustainability is a collective responsibility: Sustainable travel isn't a special kind of travel—it is an attitude towards how we travel. If only we could remember that the place we visit is someone's home, we should be able to alter many of our daily practices to be more sustainable and help those destinations be much better prepared to serve future generations. Even small decisions like carrying a water bottle or switching off the AC can have a far-reaching impact.

As we wade into the future in a world aggressively coping with the impact of climate change, one must remember that tourism has the capability to be a driver of inclusive development. Globally, airlines are already opting for innovative biofuels made from processed, used cooking oil and exploring other options such as solar power. Steps such as these help reduce the environmental impact of air travel and bring us closer to a world of clean, renewable energy.

However, no single organisation or government can create a sustainable future alone—it will take all of

us. It is vital for every individual to imbibe an eco-friendly attitude towards the way they travel, by choosing eco-conscious accommodations, travelling during off-peak seasons, minimising waste and spending locally. New-age responsible travellers are making conscious choices globally, giving precedence to clean, green and sustainable places. And this is where every Indian has a role to play—to make our country a dream destination.

Create model destinations across the country: For India to climb the global ladder as a tourism hub, the private sector and the government must provide impetus to developing many sustainable new destinations. The popular tourism hotspots are already facing intense heat and we need to provide room for these over-exploited destinations to become sustainable in the long run. By 2047, India can look at developing 200 model destinations to target travellers worldwide, helping the world experience the unexplored scenic destinations of the country. Such a step will help smaller places to develop—for tourists and locals

alike. The burgeoning homestay industry is already offering an opportunity for travellers to experience the most locally unique ways while touring the most beautiful parts of the country. The government must take steps to shape this pillar that exemplifies our ethos of '*Atithi Devo Bhava*'.

India's increased emphasis on building fast train systems and roads has significantly reduced travel times between cities to manageable single hours. The improved road infrastructure hasn't just encouraged Indians to travel more within their nation but has also had positive impacts on the auto sector. Interestingly, while international travel has yet to recover fully, domestic leisure travel has crossed pre-pandemic levels. It gives policymakers a direction—our domestic tourism market has gained critical strength and we need to nurture it. In the long run, this will only help build India's case in international markets.

In order to fully capitalise on the potential of this sector, the government must prioritise it by conferring it with "infrastructure" status and including it in the Concurrent List. This will open up the sector to much-needed investments and support from the government, allowing it to grow rapidly.

The future of tourism in India is full of promise. For the present generation of tourists, technology has already brought a revolution of discoverability and convenience. Technology is all geared to aid our future wanderlusts further, fuelling the inner adventurers to take the road less travelled with just a few mouse clicks or voice commands.

A storied life is, after all, a well-travelled one. **BT**

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